

Affinity Diagram

DirectPass | User Interview Analysis

DUXB-73

This diagram organizes the observations from the user interviews into clusters. Each cluster represents a theme that emerged from what the users said. The structure goes participant by participant first, and then shows the shared patterns at the end.

LEGEND

- Information & Research
- Financial Concerns
- Visa Process
- Tracking & Organization
- Community & Advice
- Ideal Platform

Edward

Tech / Marketing professional

From: Dublin, Ireland

Goal: Chicago, USA | MBA

Iverson

Law graduate, 4 languages

From: Paris, France

Goal: Montreal, Canada | Undecided

Joselyn

Chemistry / Marine researcher

From: Venezuela

Goal: Florida, USA | PhD

Edward

Interview findings — clusters 1 to 3

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Goes directly to official university websites

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Doesn't trust what friends say — verifies everything

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

24,000 tabs open, no RAM left

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Information from others is often outdated

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Researched 2 universities so far

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Fees are the main deciding factor

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Worried about hidden costs in US

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

In Ireland fees are clearly outlined

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Would stop the process if budget goes too high

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Wants a full cost picture before deciding

VISA PROCESS

VISA PROCESS

Knows visa is separate from admission

VISA PROCESS

Aware of DS-160 form and embassy interview

VISA PROCESS

Not 100% sure which step comes first

VISA PROCESS

Finds lots of misinformation online about visas

Edward

Interview findings — clusters 4 to 6

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Uses a personal spreadsheet

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Tracks: university, fees, location, transport

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Follows own deadlines, not external ones

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Wishes there was an automatic version of this

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Spends a lot of time building the spreadsheet

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Has a friend in Chicago — key source of info

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Recommends LinkedIn to find people who studied in US

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Willing to share own tracking spreadsheet as template

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Sees community as give and take

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Asks friend for advice 3-4 times a week

IDEAL PLATFORM

IDEAL PLATFORM

Wants one centralized website

IDEAL PLATFORM

Smart newsletter — only relevant updates

IDEAL PLATFORM

Information about the city life too

IDEAL PLATFORM

Would return if platform sends notifications on changes

IDEAL PLATFORM

Needs visa info inside the same platform

Iverson

Interview findings — clusters 1 to 3

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Uses official websites as main source

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Asks other people and documents their answers

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Too many sources make decisions harder

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Currently in very early research stage

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Financial process is the hardest part

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Education in Paris is much cheaper

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Doesn't know how to get the money for Canada

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Needs to build a real budget first

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Credit access in France is limited

VISA PROCESS

VISA PROCESS

Believes visa must come BEFORE university admission

VISA PROCESS

This is actually incorrect — needs clarification

VISA PROCESS

Finds visa info changes too often

VISA PROCESS

Wants one place to track visa requirements

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Uses Notion for notes and deadlines

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Describes himself as not a very organized person

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Needs to centralize all his documents

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Follows own deadlines, not external ones

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Rates community importance: 7 out of 10

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Has friends in US with mixed experiences

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Worried about forums with no moderation

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Too many different answers create confusion

IDEAL PLATFORM

IDEAL PLATFORM

Needs step-by-step clarity, one step at a time

IDEAL PLATFORM

Wants updates on visa and program changes

IDEAL PLATFORM

Needs community but with quality control

IDEAL PLATFORM

Would use tracking feature if available

IDEAL PLATFORM

Trusts platforms that use official sources

Joselyn

Interview findings — clusters 1 to 3

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Trusts official university + government websites

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Uses academic advisors to filter information

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Structured decisions, not peer-driven

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Country-specific info is missing from general rules

INFORMATION & RESEARCH

Blogs that repeat general info are not useful

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Created a financial plan before anything else

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Worked multiple jobs to fund her own path

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Learned to write proposals to secure funding

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Still missing info on automatic PhD funding

FINANCIAL CONCERNS

Sees financial struggle as preparation, not a barrier

VISA PROCESS

VISA PROCESS

Clearly knows admission comes before visa

VISA PROCESS

F-1 = legal authorization from government

VISA PROCESS

Needs admission + financial support first

VISA PROCESS

Treats them as two completely separate steps

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Uses an activity schedule with weekly goals

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Breaks large deadlines into smaller milestones

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Combines external and personal deadlines

TRACKING & ORGANIZATION

Tracking is structured but still fully DIY

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Describes community as ESSENTIAL

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Seeks advice from professors with intl. experience

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Knows Prof. Luis Medina's experience at Stony Brook

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Would only use forums moderated by experts

COMMUNITY & ADVICE

Comfortable sharing in safe, respectful spaces

IDEAL PLATFORM

IDEAL PLATFORM

Centralized, no excessive text

IDEAL PLATFORM

Real and up-to-date university requirements

IDEAL PLATFORM

Program comparison tool across universities

IDEAL PLATFORM

Automated calendar with deadlines

IDEAL PLATFORM

Instant alerts for funding and requirement changes

IDEAL PLATFORM

Would use ALL features: matching, visa prep, community, tracking

Shared Patterns

Observations that appeared across the interviews

These patterns are the strongest signals for what the product needs to solve first.

1

All go to official websites first

2

Fees and costs are a major concern

3

Visa vs. admission order is confusing (2 of 3)

4

All track progress with personal DIY tools

5

All want one centralized platform

6

All want updates when things change

7

Community needs moderation to be trusted

8

Emotional weight of the process is real

KEY QUOTES

"I don't want 24,000 windows on my Google Chrome and then I have no RAM left."

— Edward

"There are so many informations, different information. It is complicated to make the right decisions."

— Iverson

"I think it is important to talk about the emotional and mental impact of the process."

— Joselyn

Insights at a Glance

Summary of clusters and their main signal

	Theme	Edward	Iverson	Joselyn
	Information	Verifies on official sites, many tabs open	Official sites + notes from others	Official sites + academic advisors; missing country-specific info
	Finances	Fears hidden costs, needs full breakdown	Cannot budget, hard to access credit	Built own financial plan from day one; wants PhD auto-funding info
	Visa	Knows steps, not 100% sure of order	Believes visa must come BEFORE admission	Clearly knows admission comes first, then F-1 visa
	Tracking	Spreadsheet he built himself	Notion notes, self-described disorganized	Activity schedule with weekly goals and personal milestones
	Community	Very open, Reddit and LinkedIn	Rates 7/10, worries about bad info	Calls it ESSENTIAL; trusts expert-moderated forums only
	Ideal Platform	Central hub + smart newsletter	Clear steps + updates + moderated community	Comparison tool + auto calendar + instant alerts + all features

These clusters are the starting point for defining How Might We questions and moving into the design phase of the DirectPass project.